

Naja pallida

Red spitting cobra



Length 28–47 in (70–120 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location N. and E. Africa



This African snake is one of several cobras that have evolved a unique way of defending themselves. If threatened, they can squirt venom out of small apertures in their fangs, spraying a cloud of droplets 6½ ft (2 m) at their enemy. Sprayed venom does not kill, but it can cause permanent blindness. The red spitting cobra varies in color from red to gray, and is active at night and early in the morning. Females lay up to 15 eggs in a burrow or in rotting vegetation.



Naja haje

Egyptian cobra

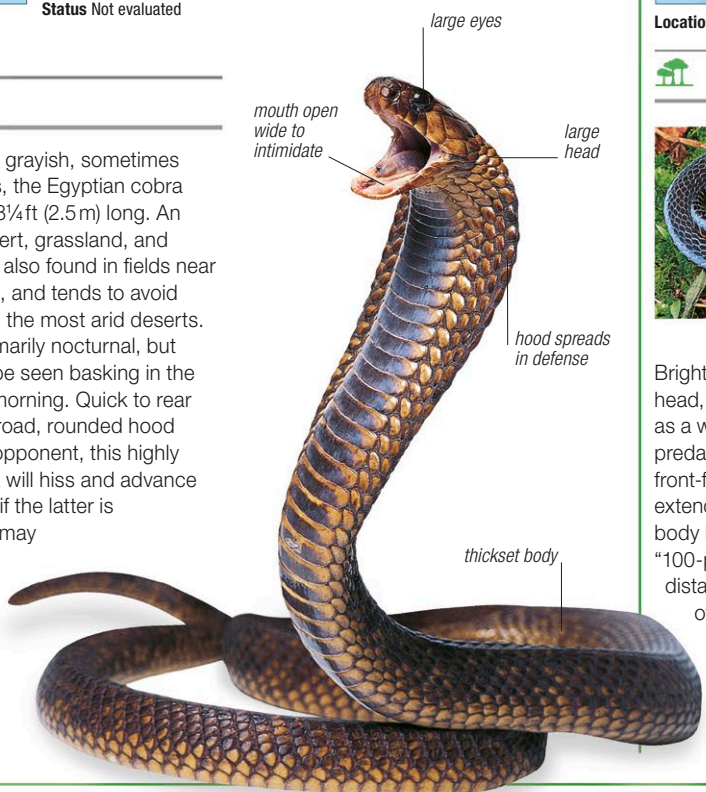


Length 3¼–7¼ ft (1–2.4 m), max 8¼ ft (2.5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location N., W., and E. Africa



Usually brown or grayish, sometimes with black bands, the Egyptian cobra may grow up to 8¼ ft (2.5 m) long. An inhabitant of desert, grassland, and urban areas, it is also found in fields near oases and wadis, and tends to avoid dense forest and the most arid deserts. This cobra is primarily nocturnal, but can sometimes be seen basking in the sun early in the morning. Quick to rear and spread its broad, rounded hood to intimidate an opponent, this highly venomous cobra will hiss and advance on its aggressor if the latter is undeterred, and may eventually strike, delivering a bite that is fatal for humans if an antivenom is not administered promptly. It actively pursues



other snakes, small mammals, toads, and birds, including domestic poultry, killing prey with its fast-acting venom; it also feeds on eggs. Individuals are territorial and frequently fight one another. Females lay 8–20 eggs, often in termite mounds, and the eggs hatch after an incubation period of about 60 days.

Calliophis bivirgata

Blue coral snake



Length 4–4½ ft (1.2–1.4 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.E. Asia



Bright orange markings on the underside, head, and tail of the blue coral snake act as a warning device to keep potential predators at bay. A highly venomous front-fanged species, its poison glands extend along almost one-third of its entire body length. It is also known as the “100-pace snake,” referring to the distance a human is thought capable of traveling before succumbing to the venom. However, it is generally inoffensive, only killing other snakes for food. Only a few cases of human fatalities have ever been recorded.



Notechis scutatus

Australian tiger snake



Length 3¼–7 ft (1–2.1 m)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.E. Australia



This extremely venomous species is responsible for many potentially fatal snake bites in Australia. It may be gray, brown, dark brown, or olive-brown, often with narrow, light yellow bands. Although active mainly during the day, the Australian tiger snake may also be active early in the morning and in the evening, and on warm nights; it remains hidden in spells of cold weather. Its prey consists mainly of frogs, which it chases then subdues with its venom. In defense, it flattens its neck and rears its body slightly off the ground. Females give birth to about 30 live young.



Ophiophagus hannah

King cobra

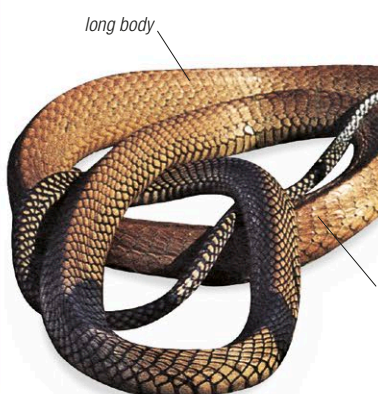


Length 9¼–16 ft (3–5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Vulnerable

Location S. and S.E. Asia



The king cobra, or hamadryad, is the longest venomous snake and a specialized hunter of other snakes. It sometimes reaches a length of more than 16 ft (5 m), which allows it to overpower and kill other snakes of a considerable size. When threatened, it raises the front third of its body so that it stands 5 ft (1.5 m) tall, erects a narrow hood, and may strike downward,



although it rarely attempts to bite. In fact, few cases of king cobra bites on humans have been recorded, because this retiring snake shuns human contact, living mainly in deep forest. Slender and smooth-scaled, the king cobra is a good swimmer and is often found near water. Adults are plain brown, while juveniles are darker and marked with pale chevrons down their backs. Unusually for a snake, this species is at least temporarily monogamous, pairs apparently remaining together during the breeding season. Females lay 21–40 eggs, mostly in piles of dead vegetation, which are guarded by both parents until they hatch. The king cobra may live for more than 20 years in captivity.



Oxyuranus scutellatus

Coastal taipan



Length 6½–12 ft (2–3.6 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location S. New Guinea, N. Australia



Although nondescript in appearance, the plain tan or dark brown coastal taipan is Australia's most venomous snake. It is shy and seldom seen, but when encountered, is capable of striking with deadly speed. It feeds mainly on mammals, but also on birds and lizards, sometimes entering burrows to trap its prey underground. Females lay 3–20 eggs each time they breed. Taipan bites can be fatal to humans, but an effective antivenom means that fatalities are now relatively rare.

